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Spotify raises subscription prices

Spotify [announced](#) on Monday that its premium subscription prices will increase for users in multiple markets across the Middle East, Africa, Europe, Latin America, and the Asia-Pacific region.

Over the next month, impacted subscribers will receive an email explaining that their monthly subscription cost will increase from €10.99 to €11.99.

Spotify made a similar [change](#) last year for users in the U.S., increasing prices from \$10.99 to \$11.99 — at the time, it marked the second instance when they had hiked prices over the last year.

These price hikes arrive after Spotify's rough earnings report last week, when the platform missed revenue expectations, causing its stock price to [drop](#) 11%. On the corresponding earnings call with investors, CEO Daniel Ek [stated](#) that he is "unhappy with where [Spotify is] today," but remained "confident in the ambitions we laid out for this business."

IMAGE CREDITS: SPOTIFY

Spotify's [shares rose 5%](#) in premarket trading after announcing the price hikes.

Topics: [In Brief](#) [Media & Entertainment](#) [Spotify](#)



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Warner Music Group signs on to SoundCloud's artist-friendly payment model

Amanda Silberling — 6:01 AM PDT · July 21, 2022

When SoundCloud launched its artist-friendly [fan-powered royalty system](#) last year, the model was only available for independent artists subscribed to the streamer's paid tiers. Now, SoundCloud has inked its first major label partnership with Warner Music Group, whose artists can now earn fan-powered royalties on the platform too.

Since the early 2000s, artists and record labels alike have struggled to figure out how musicians can make a living when it's so easy to download .mp3s online. New models like music streaming on Spotify can feel like a stop-gap, though, since payouts from these services can be [paltry](#) if you're not Lizzo or Olivia Rodrigo.

Spotify pays artists via a pro-rata model, which means there is a large pot of money that gets divided among all artists depending on how many streams they each get. But that

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means that the success of superstar musicians can inadvertently take away from the payouts of up-and-coming performers.

The user-centric model, or what SoundCloud calls [fan-powered royalties](#) (FPR), is designed to level the playing field for smaller artists.

“Under FPR, each fan’s subscription or advertising revenue is distributed among the artists they listen to, rather than being pooled under the traditional pro-rata model the music industry has been using for over a decade,” SoundCloud explained in a press release.

In its initial roll-out of FPR, only independent artists were eligible to earn FPR, and they have to pay [at least \\$30 a year](#). Now that SoundCloud has signed a licensing deal with Warner Music Group (WMG), one of the largest global record companies, even more musicians will be eligible for these payouts from SoundCloud.

Getting signed to a major label is no easy feat, so the artists this deal will benefit are already pretty established. But affiliation with WMG doesn’t always guarantee riches, especially for artists whose revenue from touring has been decimated during the coronavirus pandemic.

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Buy-in from major labels is necessary for an FPR system to work, which is why Deezer hasn't been able to widely implement a similar model yet, despite [vocally advocating](#) for it since 2019.

Meanwhile, Tidal introduced a fan-centric model in November that doesn't require buy-in from labels. In addition to standard pro-rata payouts, fans on Tidal's highest tier (\$20 per month) will see 10% of their monthly payment sent straight to their most-listened-to artist. Tidal only makes up a [small fraction](#) of the global streaming music subscription market, though.

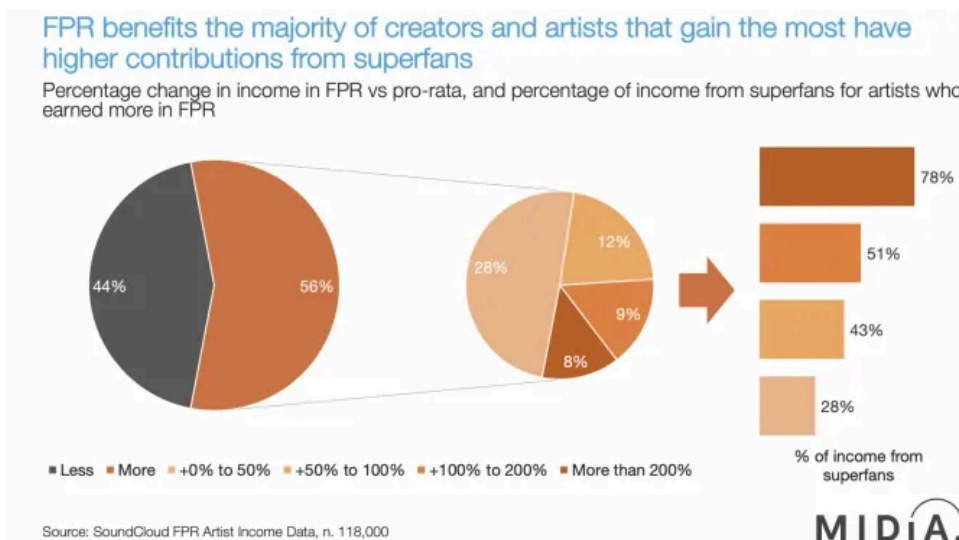


IMAGE CREDITS: [MIDiA](#)

Though SoundCloud isn't particularly popular for paid subscribers either, it hosts a ton of music — more than 300 million tracks from 30 million artists. Because SoundCloud hosts so many independent musicians, it's been easier to study how FPR works in practice.

In one of the first studies of FPR in action, entertainment research firm MIDiA analyzed FPR data from 118,000 SoundCloud musicians, finding that 56% of artists earned more under FPR than pro-rata models; but those who earned less under FPR were often larger artists with over 100,000 listeners.

MIDiA also made the interesting observation that smaller artists get larger payouts when they have “superfans,” or

listeners whose streams contribute more than ten cents a month. The report also found that FPR helps the longtail of musicians move up into higher payout brackets — SoundCloud saw a 9.2% increase in artists who earned over \$1,000 from streaming payouts between April 2021 and February 2022.

For user-driven payout models to have a significant industry effect, larger players like Spotify or Apple Music need to adopt the model and get record labels on board, which is no small task. But at the very least, SoundCloud's deal with WMG is promising news.

[SoundCloud acquires Musiio, an AI music curator, to improve discovery](#)

[Spotify adds more artists to its Blend tool, allows fans to buy merch via the feature](#)

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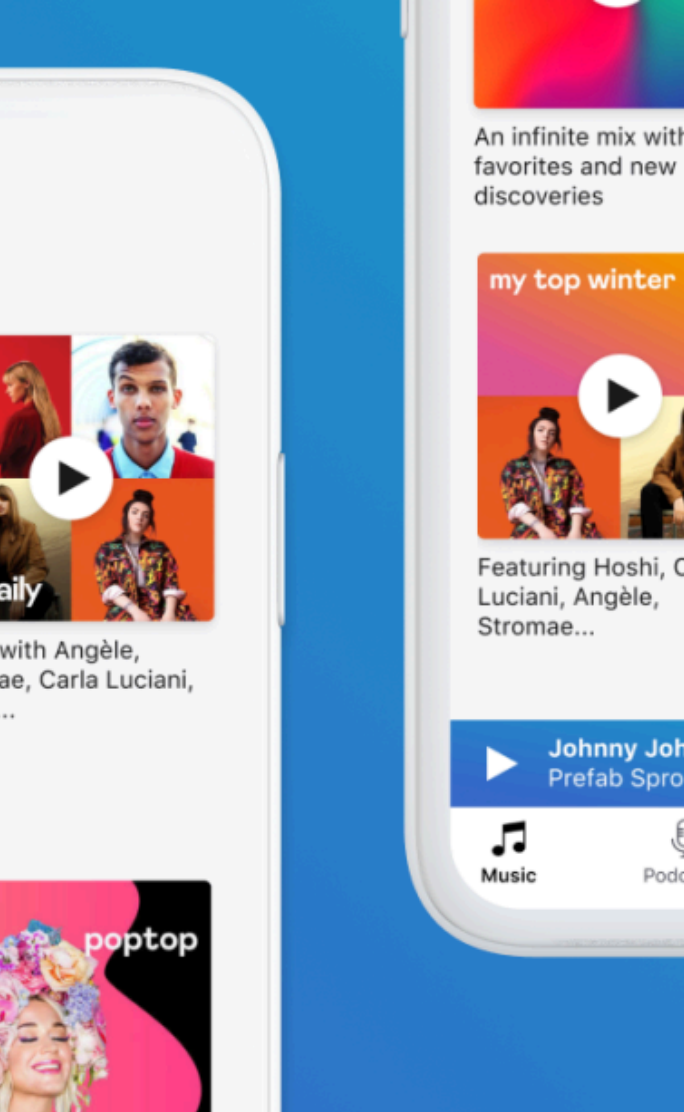
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Music streamer Deezer is going public via SPAC at a \$1.1B valuation

Amanda Silberling — 2:33 PM PDT · April 18, 2022

A European music streamer, Deezer is going public via a [SPAC deal](#), valuing the Spotify competitor at \$1.1 billion. Deezer will merge with the “blank-check” company I2PO, which is headed by former WarnerMedia executive Iris Knobloch.

Founded in 2007, the company previously [tried to IPO](#) in 2015, only to reverse course and raise [Series E](#) and Series F rounds in 2016 and 2018. Around the time of its first attempt at an IPO, investors were worried about the profitability of music streaming, since Pandora had just [lost nearly \\$86 million](#) in one quarter.

Since then, highly resourced streamers like Spotify, Amazon and Apple have only continued to grow, renewing market interest in music. But Deezer has also struggled to compete with these behemoths — as of Q2 2021, Deezer [only held 2%](#) of the global streaming music subscription market, though it’s more popular abroad than in the U.S. In France and Brazil, the company [holds 29% and 17%](#) of the market share respectively.

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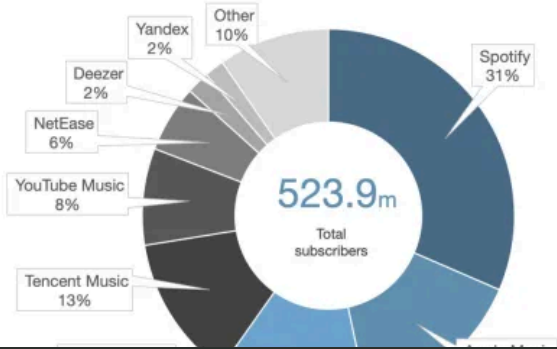


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Global streaming music subscription market, Q2 2021

Global streaming music subscription market, Q2 2021, global



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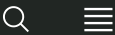
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“Today marks an important milestone in Deezer’s history as we embark on a journey to become a publicly traded company on Euronext Paris,” said Jeronimo Folgueira, Deezer’s CEO, in a statement. “We are uniquely positioned on the growing music streaming industry, with a very competitive product, a clear strategy and an experienced and renewed management team to seize this opportunity and create substantial shareholder value.”

Unpacking music streaming economics through the lens of Deezer’s SPAC

The Exchange procured Deezer's release and investor presentation. Let's parse the data and see what the economics of a smaller music streaming business look like today.



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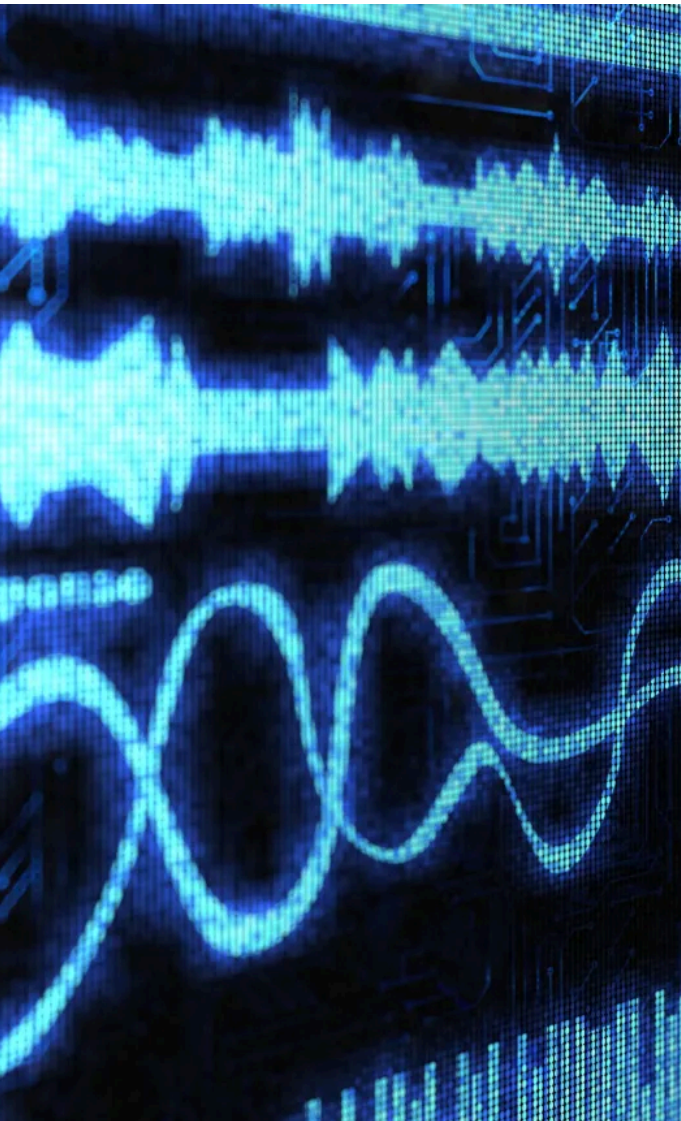


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Spotify still tops other music services, but its market share declined

Amanda Silberling — 2:21 PM PST · January 20, 2022

Music streaming is continuing to grow around the world. According to a new [report from MIDiA](#), an entertainment research firm, 523.9 million people subscribed to a music streaming service globally as of the second quarter of 2021. This marks a 109.5 million (26.4%) increase since the previous year.

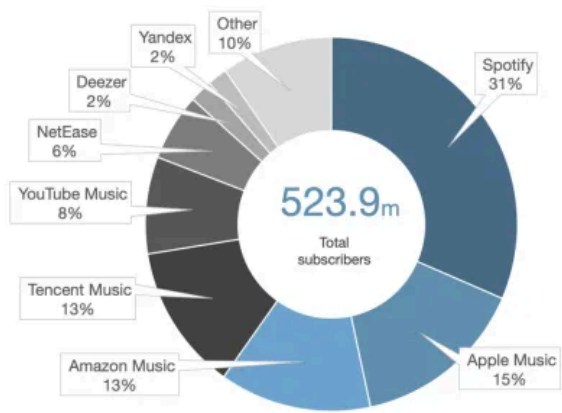
Though Spotify remains the most-subscribed streaming service, owning 31% of the market, its dominance is very slowly decreasing — it held 33% of the market in 2020, and 34% in 2019. Spotify added more total subscribers in the year leading up to Q2 2021 than its competitors, but while Spotify

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grew by 20%, Amazon Music grew by 25%. Meanwhile, Google's YouTube Music grew by more than 50% over the year leading up to Q2 2021, making it the only Western streamer to have increased its overall share of the global market. The Chinese gaming giant Tencent, which operates Tencent Music, owns the same percent market share as Amazon Music.

Global streaming music subscription market, Q2 2021

Global streaming music subscription market, Q2 2021, global



Source: MIDiA Research Music Subscriber Market Share Model 11/21

MIDiA

IMAGE CREDITS: MIDiA

The market share of Amazon Music and Apple Music may continue to grow — because this report only covers up to Q2 2021, it won't show the impact of lossless audio coming to both [Amazon](#) and [Apple](#) in May. Nearly a year ago, Spotify teased that it would launch a high-end subscription called [Spotify Hi-Fi](#), which would give subscribers their music in a "CD-quality, lossless audio format." But Spotify [still hasn't said](#) when this product might become available.

And then there's Tidal, which has historically targeted consumers who seek a higher-quality audio experience. Though Tidal's lossless audio tier is \$9.99 per month — the same cost as Apple Music, and just two dollars a month more than Amazon Music — Tidal owns less than 2% of global market share, according to MIDiA's report. Founded by Jay-Z and later [acquired](#) by Block, Tidal markets itself as a service that helps artists share their music "precisely as the artist intended" (i.e. with extremely good audio quality).

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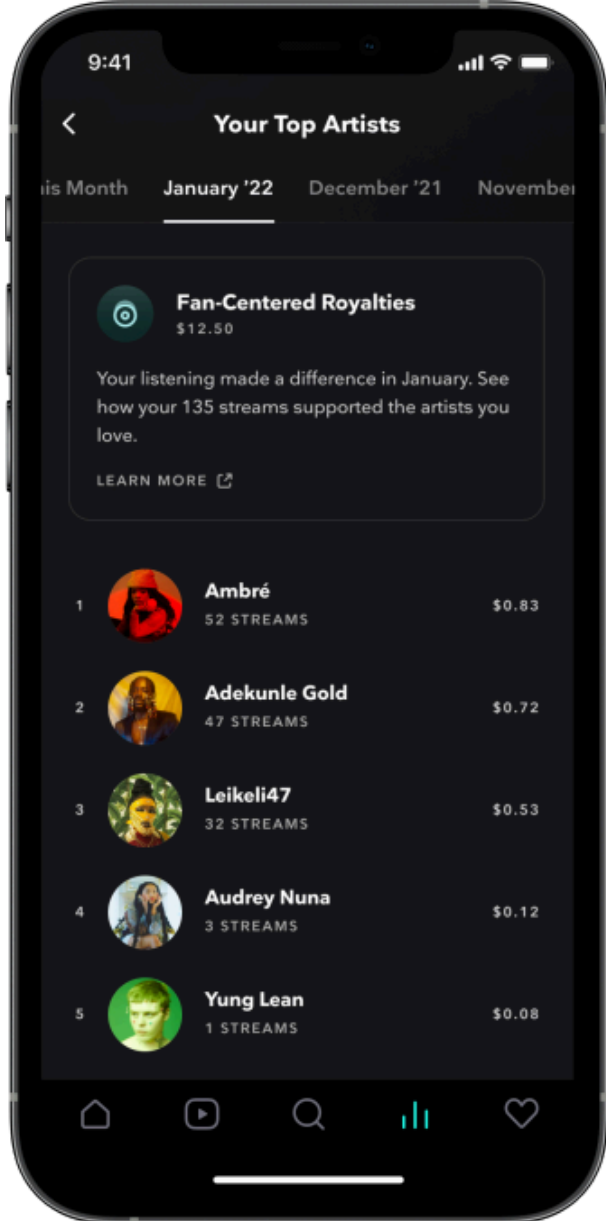


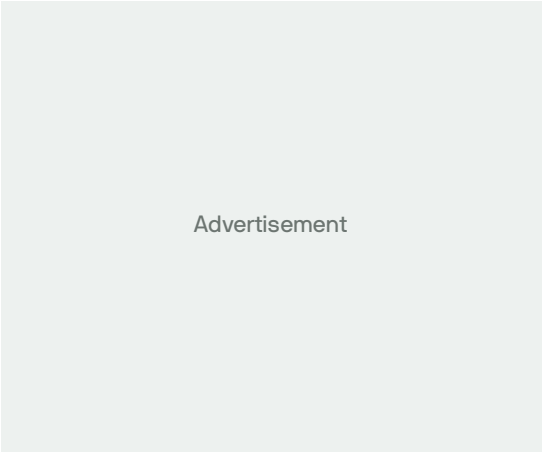
IMAGE CREDITS: TIDAL

But under Block's ownership, the idea of an artist-friendly streaming service isn't just about sound — now, the company is experimenting with ways to make music streaming more profitable for artists. At the start of this year, Tidal introduced [direct-artist payouts](#) to its top HiFi Plus tier (\$19.99/month), which means that 10% of a user's subscription will go directly to their most-listened-to artists. Later in 2022, it will roll out fan-centered royalties, which means that artists will be paid based on individual users' streaming habits.

Will this move help Tidal earn new subscribers who care about paying artists more than master-quality audio? It's a worthy try — after all, Deezer (which is working to implement [user-centric payments](#)) has a full 2% of the pie, which is more than Tidal.

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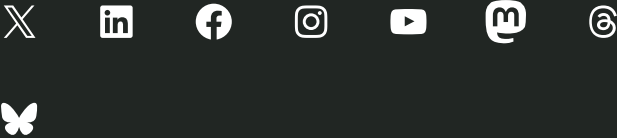
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